

On-call runbook: checkout

Version 3.2 · Owner: SRE · Last reviewed 2026-06-30 · Applies to gateway, orders, payments, orders-db and labels-worker

1. Purpose

Use this runbook when you are paged for checkout errors or checkout latency. It covers the first 30 minutes: stop the bleeding, then find the cause. Write the postmortem afterwards (section 6).

2. Services and owners

Service	What it does	Owner	Channel
gateway	Public checkout API. Calls orders.	Platform team	#team-platform
orders	Creates orders, normalizes addresses, builds shipping labels, calls payments.	Orders team	#team-orders
payments	Charges cards through the payment provider, with retries.	Payments team	#team-payments
orders-db	Postgres for orders. Connection pool of 20 per orders pod.	SRE	#team-sre
labels-worker	Sends label jobs to the warehouse printer vendor.	Labels team	#team-labels

3. When you are paged for checkout errors

The page fires when the checkout 5xx rate is above 2% for 5 minutes.

- 3.1 Acknowledge the page within 5 minutes. Open an incident channel named #inc-<date>-checkout and post the alert link.
- 3.2 Open the Checkout dashboard. Note the error rate and which service returns the errors.
- 3.3 Check the deploy log for the last 30 minutes. **If any service was deployed in the last 15 minutes, roll back the most recent deploy first, then investigate.** Recent deploys cause most of our incidents.
- 3.4 If the orders DB pool is above 90%, restart the orders pods to free connections.
- 3.5 If errors continue for 30 minutes after mitigation, escalate to the owning team's secondary on-call (section 7).
- 3.6 Post an update in the incident channel every 30 minutes, even when nothing has changed.

Tip. Rolling back is cheap and safe for every service except orders-db migrations. When in doubt, roll back first.

4. Rollback procedure

Roll back one service at a time and watch the error rate for 5 minutes before touching the next one.

```
deployctl rollback <service> --to previous --reason "INC <id>"
deployctl status <service>
```

A rollback takes about 4 minutes. Feature flags that shipped with the deploy are reset to their previous values.

5. Known issues

Symptom	What it usually means	What to do
payments p95 latency up to 450 ms	Provider latency spike. Common and usually harmless.	Watch. Page Payments only if errors rise too.
Labels missing in the warehouse	Printer vendor outage or encoding problem. See PM-2026-07-18.	Check labels-worker logs, then page the Labels team.
orders-db pool above 90%	Traffic spike or slow queries.	Step 3.4.

6. After the incident

Write a blameless postmortem within three business days, using the Brightcart postmortem template (postmortem-template.docx). Link every claim to evidence. Track action items until they are closed.

7. Escalation

Level	Who	How
1	Primary on-call of the service returning errors	Page through the on-call tool
2	Secondary on-call of that service	Page after 30 minutes without mitigation
3	Engineering manager on duty	Page for SEV-1, or for SEV-2 lasting over 60 minutes

Revision history

Version	Date	Change
3.2	2026-06-30	Added the labels-worker service and the known-issues table.
3.1	2026-03-12	Step 3.3: roll back the most recent deploy first when a deploy landed in the last 15 minutes.
3.0	2025-11-04	Rewritten for the gateway, orders and payments split.